TEXORA · COURSE NOTES · LECTURE SHEET

Culture and Related Concepts

What culture is and what it is made of, its main types, the part it plays inside organisations, and socialization — the process by which culture enters the person.

HUM-2209 · SOCIOLOGY AND HUMAN ECOLOGY · TOPIC 2 · LEVEL 2 TERM 2

1. What culture is

In everyday speech “culture” means refinement — music, literature, good manners. In sociology it means far more: the whole way of life of a people. The classic definition is still Edward B. Tylor's (1871): culture is *“that complex whole which includes knowledge, belief, art, morals, law, custom, and any other capabilities and habits acquired by man as a member of society.”* Every word of the ending matters: culture is **acquired**, not inborn, and it is acquired **as a member of society** — through other people.

The characteristics of culture follow from this definition:

- **Learned** — nobody is born with a language, a dress sense or table manners; all are taught and imitated.
- **Shared** — culture belongs to a group; a habit possessed by one eccentric person is not culture until others share it.
- **Transmitted** — it passes from generation to generation through language, schooling and example, which is why societies have continuity.
- **Symbolic** — it rests on symbols whose meaning is agreed: words, flags, wedding rings, a red traffic light.
- **Integrated** — its parts hang together; change the economy and family life, dress and food begin to change too.
- **Dynamic** — it never stands still; each generation modifies what it receives, slowly or, in our century, very fast.
- **Adaptive** — it is humanity's main tool for adjusting to the environment: clothing, housing, farming and medicine are all cultural answers to nature.

2. Elements of culture

ELEMENT	MEANING	EXAMPLES

Language	The system of symbols by which members communicate and store experience	Bangla and its dialects; technical terms of a trade; sign language
Values	Shared ideas of what is good, right and desirable	Honesty, hospitality, respect for elders, hard work
Beliefs	Convictions about what is true	Religious beliefs; beliefs about health, luck, the causes of illness
Norms	Rules that guide behaviour in specific situations	See folkways, mores and laws below
Symbols	Anything that stands for something else by agreement	The national flag, a uniform, a wedding ring, a company logo
Technology	The tools, techniques and material equipment of the group	The plough, the power loom, the smartphone

Norms themselves come in grades of strictness. **Folkways** are the ordinary customs of daily life — how to greet, dress, eat; breaking them brings mild disapproval. **Mores** are norms tied to morality, whose violation shocks the group — dishonesty, cruelty, disrespect to parents. **Laws** are norms written and enforced by the state, with formal punishment. A single act can sit at several levels: theft breaks a folkway of honesty, the mores of the community and the law of the land at once.

Culture is also divided into **material culture** — the physical objects a group makes and uses (buildings, machines, garments) — and **non-material culture** — the intangible creations (language, values, beliefs, norms). The two do not change at the same speed: material culture usually races ahead, and the strain while non-material culture catches up is what William F. Ogburn called **cultural lag**. The smartphone arrived in a decade; the manners and laws for using it are still catching up.

3. Types of culture

- **Material and non-material culture** — as above: objects versus ideas, rules and skills.
- **High culture** — the refined tastes of the educated elite: classical music, literature, fine art. **Popular (mass) culture** — the commercially produced entertainment of the majority: film songs, television serials, social-media trends.
- **Subculture** — the distinct way of life of a group *within* the larger society: students, garments workers, a religious community, the fishermen of the coast. Subcultures differ from the mainstream but live inside it.

- **Counterculture** — a subculture that consciously rejects and opposes the dominant values — protest movements that deny mainstream ideas of success, dress or authority.
- **Dominant culture** — the culture of the group holding most power and numbers, whose norms tend to be treated as "the" culture of the society.
- **Ideal culture versus real culture** — what a society says it values (honesty in trade) versus what its members actually practise; the gap between the two is itself a sociological fact worth studying.

4. Culture in the organisation

Every organisation develops its own culture: the shared values, beliefs and habits that tell members "how things are done here." It is visible in rituals (the morning briefing, the annual picnic), in stories (how the founder saved the firm), in heroes (the worker everyone respects), in dress and language, and in unwritten rules that no handbook contains.

Organisational culture does real work:

- **Identity and belonging** — members feel part of something, which steadies morale and loyalty.
- **Informal control** — a strong safety culture stops the shortcut that no inspector is watching for; a weak one lets "everybody does it" excuse it.
- **Coordination** — shared assumptions mean less need for written instruction on every small matter.
- **Resistance, when it must change** — the same culture that stabilises a factory can block a necessary reform; new machinery fails more often from an unshifted culture than from the machine itself.

In a garment factory, for example, whether protective gear is actually worn depends less on the rule book than on whether the floor culture treats the gear as normal or as a nuisance. Changing behaviour there means changing culture — topic 9 returns to this problem as *resistance to change*.

5. Socialization

Socialization is the lifelong process by which a person learns the culture of his society — its language, norms, values and roles — and develops a self. It is how a biological infant becomes a social person. Without it, as cases of severely isolated children grimly show, language, manners and even ordinary human responses do not develop on their own.

Types of socialization

- **Primary socialization** — the learning of earliest childhood, above all within the family: language, basic manners, the sense of right and wrong. Deepest and most lasting.
- **Secondary socialization** — learning for specific roles later in life: the schoolchild's discipline, the worker's training, the officer's code.

- **Anticipatory socialization** — rehearsing a role one hopes to enter: the student who already adopts the habits and dress of the profession he is preparing for.
- **Resocialization** — the deliberate unmaking and remaking of a person's values and behaviour, as in military training, rehabilitation or joining a strict religious order.

Agents of socialization

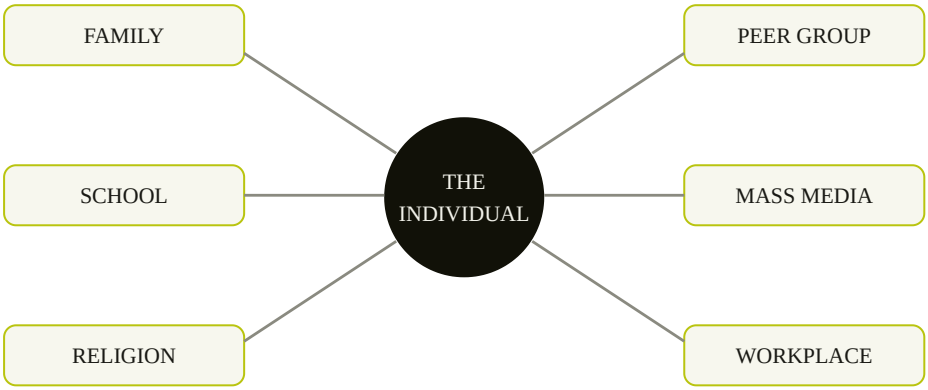


Figure 1 — The main agents of socialization surround the individual through life; the family speaks first, the others join as the person grows.

AGENT	WHAT IT TEACHES
Family	First language, first norms, emotional security, religion, the child's earliest sense of self. The strongest agent of all.
Peer group	Equality, independence from adults, fashion, slang, the standards of one's own generation — increasingly powerful in adolescence.
School	Formal knowledge, discipline, punctuality, competition, and the hidden curriculum of obedience to impersonal rules.
Mass media	News, tastes, lifestyles and ambitions far beyond one's own locality — for good and for ill.
Religion	Moral codes, rituals, answers to questions of suffering and death, and a community of belonging.
Workplace	Adult secondary socialization: skills, hierarchy, time discipline, professional identity.

Stages across the life cycle

Socialization never stops; only its agents and tasks change. In **childhood** the family dominates and the self is formed. In **adolescence** peers and media gain ground and identity is tested. In **adulthood** work, marriage and parenthood teach new roles. In **old age** the person adjusts to retirement, reduced roles and

the approach of death. A society that cares for all four stages socialises gently; one that abandons any of them produces the misfits it then punishes.

6. Glossary — key terms of this topic

TERM	MEANING
Culture	The complex whole of knowledge, belief, art, morals, law, custom and habits acquired by a person as a member of society (Tylor).
Folkways	Everyday customs whose breach earns only mild disapproval.
Mores	Norms bound up with morality, whose breach shocks the community.
Cultural lag	Ogburn's term for the strain when material culture changes faster than the non-material culture that should regulate it.
Subculture	The distinctive way of life of a group within a larger society.
Socialization	The lifelong process of learning a society's culture and forming a self.
Resocialization	The radical remaking of a person's values and behaviour, usually in a controlled institution.

7. Key points and summary

- Culture is learned, shared, transmitted, symbolic, integrated and dynamic; Tylor's definition is the standard starting point.
- Its elements are language, values, beliefs, norms (folkways, mores, laws), symbols and technology; it divides into material and non-material parts, which change at unequal speeds (cultural lag).
- Within one society live high and popular culture, subcultures, sometimes countercultures, and often a gap between ideal and real culture.
- Organisations have cultures too; a strong floor culture controls behaviour more reliably than the rule book.
- Socialization — primary, secondary, anticipatory, resocialization — runs from cradle to grave through family, peers, school, media, religion and workplace.

8. Practice

Answer in your own words; brief model answers follow.

1. Give Tylor's definition of culture and explain the two phrases “acquired” and “as a member of society”.
2. Classify each as folkway, more or law: (a) eating with the right hand at a village meal; (b) cheating in an examination; (c) driving without a licence; (d) queueing at a ticket counter.
3. Explain cultural lag using one example drawn from the mobile phone.
4. A factory's rule book orders helmets, yet new workers stop wearing them within a month. Use the idea of organisational culture to explain, and state what would actually change the behaviour.
5. Distinguish primary from secondary socialization, naming the chief agent of each.
6. “The peer group is the family's rival in adolescence.” Discuss in four or five sentences.

Answer key

1. Culture is “that complex whole which includes knowledge, belief, art, morals, law, custom, and any other capabilities and habits acquired by man as a member of society.” “Acquired” — learned, not inborn; “as a member of society” — learned from others, through membership of a group, not invented alone.
2. (a) Folkway — custom, mildly enforced. (b) More — a moral norm (dishonesty), also usually a formal rule. (c) Law — state-enforced. (d) Folkway — expected custom of public order.
3. Material culture (the smartphone itself) spread within years, while the non-material rules for it — etiquette, examination rules, traffic law about phone use while driving — developed slowly and are still disputed; that gap and its frictions are cultural lag.
4. The floor culture — what respected old hands actually do — teaches louder than the book. Helmets signal inexperience there, so newcomers conform to the real norm. Behaviour changes when supervisors and senior workers visibly wear them and the group, not only the rule, demands it.
5. Primary: childhood learning of language, manners and first values; chief agent the family. Secondary: later learning for specific roles (student, worker, officer); chief agents school and workplace.
6. In adolescence approval shifts: peers supply the audience whose opinion stings most, and their norms on dress, speech and risk often contradict the family's. The rivalry is rarely total — family values persist underneath — but on visible daily choices the peer group usually wins, which is why parents fear “bad company.”